

The Hidden Labor of AI

Before an AI can speak, see, or reason — millions of humans must teach it. Their work is invisible. Their wages are not.

WHAT IS DATA LABELING?

RAW DATA Millions of text snippets, images, audio clips scraped from the internet <i>Source: the open web</i>	HUMAN LABELER Workers read, tag, and rank every piece — including graphic content <i>Often: Kenya, India, Philippines</i>	LABELED DATASET Clean, categorized data used to train and 'align' AI models like ChatGPT <i>Result: AI learns what's 'safe'</i>	AI PRODUCT Polished chatbot sold to millions — human labor made invisible <i>Profit: Silicon Valley</i>
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THE NUMBERS

\$1.32 Minimum take-home hourly wage for Kenyan data labelers working for OpenAI via Sama (2021–22)	\$12.50 What OpenAI paid Sama per hour — 6–9x what workers actually received	\$19.7B Global data labeling market size in 2024 — projected to hit \$134.7B by 2034
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WHO EARNS WHAT? (HOURLY WAGE COMPARISON)

OpenAI (revenue per user)	~\$300+/hr equiv.
Sama (billed to OpenAI)	\$12.50/hr
Nairobi receptionist (min wage)	\$1.52/hr
Sama data labeler (take-home)	\$1.32–\$2/hr

A WORKER'S ACCOUNT

"That was torture. You will read a number of statements like that all through the week. By the time it gets to Friday, you are disturbed."

— Sama worker in Nairobi, Kenya, speaking to TIME Magazine (Jan. 2023). Workers were exposed to graphic descriptions of violence, self-harm, and child abuse — with limited access to mental health support.

WHO HOLDS THE POWER?

AI Companies (OpenAI, Google, Meta) – Set contracts without transparency – Do not disclose outsourcing partners – Capture nearly all profits – Distance themselves from labor conditions	Data Labelers (Kenya, India, Philippines) – Contract workers, not employees – No job security or benefits – Exposed to traumatic content – Invisible in the AI 'success story'
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Hicks's "cis-tem" applied: AI systems are built with assumptions about whose labor is invisible. The infrastructure of "clean" AI depends on workers in the Global South absorbing harm so platforms stay profitable. Making this labor visible is itself a political act.

THE "GHOST WORK" PHENOMENON

Platforms used	Worker location	Worker status
Amazon Mechanical Turk, Scale AI, Appen, Sama	Primarily Global South: Kenya, India, Philippines, Venezuela	Gig / contract — no benefits, no protections, no attribution

SOURCES

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